of humor—but she did, she always did! That was one of our little secrets. In fact, in every photo of us, whenever we're exchanging a glance, making solid eye contact, it's clear: We had secrets.

Special relationship, that's what they said about us, and now I couldn't stop thinking about the specialness that would no longer be. The visits that wouldn't take place.

Ah well, I told myself, that's just the deal, isn't it? That's life.

Still, as with so many partings, I just wished there'd been…one more goodbye.

Soon after our return, a hummingbird got into the house. I had a devil of a time guiding it out, and the thought occurred that maybe we should start shutting the doors, despite those heavenly ocean breezes.

Then a mate said: Could be a sign, you know?

Some cultures see hummingbirds as spirits, he said. Visitors, as it were. Aztecs thought them reincarnated warriors. Spanish explorers called them "resurrection birds."

You don't say?

I did some reading and learned that not only are hummingbirds visitors, they're voyagers. The lightest birds on the planet, and the fastest, they travel vast distances—from Mexican winter homes to Alaskan nesting grounds. Whenever you see a hummingbird, what you're actually seeing is a tiny, glittering Odysseus.

So, naturally, when this hummingbird arrived, and swooped around our kitchen, and flitted through the sacred airspace we call Lili Land, where we've set the baby's playpen with all her toys and stuffed animals, I thought hopefully, greedily, foolishly:

Is our house a detour—or a destination?

For half a second I was tempted to let the hummingbird be. Let it stay.

But no.

Gently I used Archie's fishing net to scoop it from the ceiling, carry it outside.

Its legs felt like eyelashes, its wings like flower petals.

With cupped palms I set the hummingbird gently on a wall in the sun.